

Doughnuts with sweet potato custard *Sonhos com creme de batata doce*

Makes around 20

14 ounces/400 g sweet potatoes

For the dough

1 cup/250 ml whole milk

$\frac{3}{4}$ cup plus 2 tablespoons/200 g butter

2 cups plus 2 tablespoons/300 g

all-purpose flour

A pinch of fine sea salt

5 eggs

For the sweet potato custard

2 egg yolks

5 tablespoons/50 g all-purpose flour

2 cups/500 ml whole milk

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup/100 g superfine sugar

1 vanilla pod, split lengthwise

1 cinnamon stick

Finely grated zest of 1 orange

Vegetable oil, for frying

Superfine sugar, for dusting

Sonhos means “dreams” in Portuguese, probably thanks to the lightness of the doughnuts or the fact that once you eat one, you will keep dreaming about it. In Lisbon they are usually eaten around Christmastime, but I make them whenever I feel like it. Some traditional recipes for *sonhos* include pumpkin or sweet potato, used here in the custard. My *sonhos* are lighter and slightly less sweet than the ones you’ll find in Portugal.

Preheat the oven to 390°F/200°C (convection 355°F/180°C).

Put the sweet potatoes on a baking sheet and roast for 45 minutes, or until cooked through. Leave to cool slightly, then peel and purée with an immersion blender until smooth.

To make the dough — Heat the milk, 1 cup/250 ml of water, and the butter in a pan over medium heat. Sift the flour onto a sheet of baking parchment. When the butter has melted, tip in the flour all at once, using the baking parchment as a chute. Beat with a spatula until the dough comes away from the side of the pan. Remove from the heat and keep beating until the dough has cooled and thickened. Add about $\frac{3}{4}$ cup/160 g of the sweet potato purée and the salt and stir well. Beat in the eggs one by one, making sure that each one is fully incorporated before adding the next, until the dough is smooth and glossy. You may not need to add all the eggs. Transfer to a bowl, cover, and refrigerate for 30 minutes.

To make the sweet potato custard — Whisk the egg yolks and flour in a bowl. Heat the rest of the ingredients with about $\frac{3}{4}$ cup/200 g of the sweet potato purée in a pan over medium heat, whisking well. Gradually pour the hot mixture over the yolks. Strain it back into the pan and cook for about 6 minutes over low heat, stirring continuously, until thickened.

To fry the doughnuts, fill a large, heavy-bottomed pan one-third full with oil and heat until it reaches 355°F/180°C (or until a cube of bread sizzles and turns golden brown almost immediately). Using 2 tablespoons, spoon the dough into the pan in small batches, frying for a few minutes, turning as needed, until golden brown. Remove and drain on paper towels. Roll the doughnuts in superfine sugar while still warm. Serve with the custard on the side for dipping.